

Scrub and Sandhills

PHOTO BY GABE ANDRLE



PLASTERER BEE (*CAUPOLICANA ELECTA*) BY
ERICA SIMMONS, INATURALIST

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Georgia's scrub and sandhill regions have long been important to forestry, especially during the era of the naval stores industry, when longleaf pine in these dry, sandy soils was tapped for turpentine and pitch.

Because the deep, well-drained sands were poor for agriculture, these areas were often reserved for pine silviculture, making them a stable and long-term source of timber. Their dry conditions also provided reliable logging access, even in wet seasons.

Over time, intensive harvesting, fire suppression, and planting of off-site species altered the structure of native pine-dominated sandhill ecosystems.

Today, these lands are being managed more sustainably, with the return of prescribed fire, BMP-guided harvesting, and efforts to restore longleaf ecosystems for both timber and biodiversity.

SWAP Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Longleaf Pine-
Scrub Oak
Woodlands

Southeastern
Plains and
Southern Coastal
Plain Ecoregions

Xeric Aeolian
Dunes

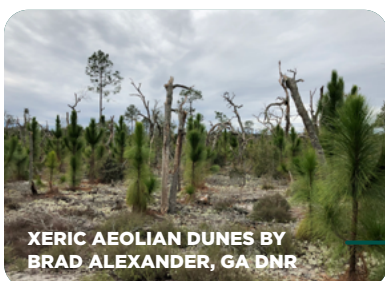
Southeastern
Plains

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

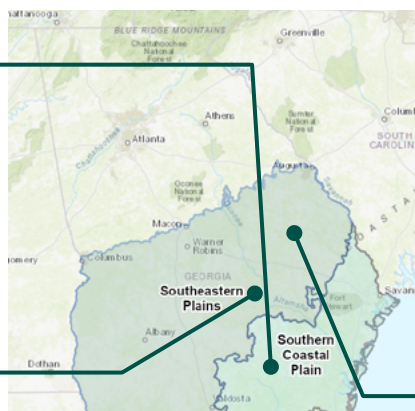
Sandhill habitats are primarily found along the Fall Line from Columbus to Augusta and along major streams such as the Altamaha, Ohoopsee, Flint, and Canoochee Rivers. Some sandhill habitats are ancient wind-formed dune systems usually found along the eastern sides of rivers and on ridges and upper slopes. Longleaf Pine-Scrub Oak Woodlands consist of a sparse canopy of longleaf pine with a patchy oak understory, including turkey oak, sand post oak, bluejack oak, blackjack oak, and other scrub oak species. This habitat contains a diverse groundcover of grasses, flowering plants, and scattered shrubs. Xeric Aeolian Dunes share a similar pine-oak component, but their deeper, sandier soils support fewer groundcover species and are often dominated by patches of wiregrass and lichens. Several rare plant species may also be found on these dunes. Isolated wetlands that occur within these sandhills are particularly important habitats for several rare amphibian species.



LONGLEAF PINE GOPHER APPLE
SANDHILL BY ALAN CRESSLER



XERIC AEOLIAN DUNES BY
BRAD ALEXANDER, GA DNR



LONGLEAF PINE SCRUB, FIRE
SUPPRESSED SANDHILL BY BRAD
ALEXANDER, GA DNR

THREATS

- Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development
- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Overstocked stands can degrade habitat by creating closed canopy conditions and reducing sunlight on the ground.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Avoid bedding, mechanical site preparation, and other soil disturbances.
- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.
- Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.
- Gopher tortoise burrows should be marked and avoided prior to logging operations. If Eastern indigo snakes occur on the site, avoid logging activities on these sandhills during their wintering season from November to March.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species
via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard
for more information and resources

